STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



PEOPLE

WHY PEOPLE LEAVE AND WHAT KEEPS THEM

What people who left say could have kept them, why they name other reasons than their employers expect, what research says about staying, and a card for the conversation before the resignation.

42% of people who left voluntarily said their manager or organisation could have done something to keep them.

GALLUP, 2024

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Every manager knows the moment: a good person asks for five minutes and hands in their notice. Our focus is the months before that meeting, when the departure could still have been a conversation.

Gallup asked 717 people in the US who had left a job, and four in ten said it could have been prevented. McKinsey found that leavers name other reasons than their employers expect. Research on why people stay points to three things: the ties a person has, how well they fit, and what they would lose by leaving. Most of the data are from the US and other English-speaking countries; for Albania and Germany we have no comparable survey.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

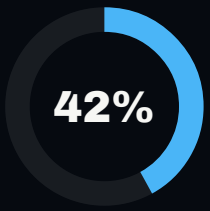
Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Four in ten could have stayed

In late 2023 Gallup surveyed 717 people in the US who had left an employer of their own choice in the previous twelve months. The sample was chosen to represent the country.



said their manager or organisation could have done something to keep them.

Share of 717 people in the US who had left an employer of their own choice in the previous twelve months (Gallup, late 2023). Their view looking back.

45%

had no conversation with a manager or any other leader about their satisfaction, performance or future in the three months before they left

½–2×

a year's salary: what Gallup estimated in 2019 it costs to replace an employee

Gallup called that estimate conservative, and put the cost of voluntary turnover to businesses in the US at about a trillion dollars a year.

OUR READING

Four in ten still leaves room for departures nobody could have stopped. What the figure shows is that many people leave without anyone having asked what would make them stay.

Sources: Corey Tatel & Ben Wigert, Gallup, 2024; Shane McFeely & Ben Wigert, Gallup, 2019

THE NUMBERS

What employers think, what leavers say

In 2021 McKinsey asked 5,774 employees and 250 employers in Australia, Canada, Singapore, the UK and the US why people were quitting. Employers pointed to pay, work–life balance and health. People who had left in the previous six months named something else.

OF THOSE WHO HAD LEFT, THE SHARE WHO…



41%
named a lack of career development and advancement, the first reason on the list in 2022

40%
were thinking of leaving their job in 2022, as many as a year earlier

OUR READING

Employers looked for the reason in the contract. Many of the people who left found it in their working relationships.

Sources: Aaron De Smet et al., McKinsey Quarterly, 2021 (via Excerpts, through web search); McKinsey & Company, 2022 (via Excerpts, through web search)

Each person could name several reasons, so the shares add up to more than 100%. The 2022 survey had 13,382 employees in six countries, India among them.

THE MODEL

Why people stay

In 2001 Terence Mitchell and colleagues asked the opposite question: not why people leave, but what holds them. They called it job embeddedness and described three parts, each at work and outside it.

Links

01 At work: colleagues, a team, someone to learn from

02 Outside: family and friends nearby

Fit

01 At work: the job uses what the person can do

02 Outside: the town and the commute suit them

Sacrifice

01 At work: a schedule, a project, the years built up

02 Outside: a home, a school, a routine

In their study, embeddedness predicted who would leave, beyond job satisfaction, commitment to the organisation, the alternatives people had and whether they were looking.

Thomas Lee and Terence Mitchell had already proposed that many departures do not grow slowly out of dissatisfaction. They start with an event that makes a person think about leaving, which the authors call a shock. It can be good or bad, at work or at home.

OUR READING

Keeping people means removing reasons to leave and also adding reasons to stay: a tie, a fit, something worth keeping.

Sources: Terence R. Mitchell et al., Academy of Management Journal, 2001 (via Abstract); Thomas W. Lee et al., Academy of Management Journal, 1999 (via Secondary summaries of the model)

The three parts are Mitchell's; the examples in them are the editors'.

WHAT THE MANAGER CAN DO

The conversation that did not happen

Almost half of Gallup's leavers had no conversation about their satisfaction, performance or future in their last three months. That conversation costs less than any other way of keeping people.

1. **Ask before they decide**
   A short conversation about staying every quarter, in addition to the exit interview.
2. **Ask about ties, fit and loss**
   The three parts of embeddedness, in plain words.
3. **Listen for a shock**
   An offer, a change at home, a reorganisation: talk in the same week.
4. **Do one thing, and say when**
   A conversation without a follow-up teaches people not to answer next time.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A SHIFT LEAD

Signal	A good team member asks twice about the night shift
Conversation	Ten minutes: what keeps you, what would make you look elsewhere
Follow-up	Schedule checked with planning by Friday

The talk happens in the week of the signal, long before any exit interview. (An invented case.)

Source: Corey Tatel & Ben Wigert, Gallup, 2024

The steps and the example come from the editors.

More in the essay — Leading people without losing the person

HOW IT IS MEASURED

What a departure costs

The US Bureau of Labor Statistics counts quits as separations the employee starts, and the quits rate as the quits of a month as a share of employment. In August 2026 it was 1.9%; at its peak, in November 2021, it was 3.0%.

21%
of a year's salary: the typical cost of replacing an employee in US case studies

16%
for jobs paying under $30,000 a year

213%
the highest, among senior and executive jobs

Heather Boushey and Sarah Jane Glynn reviewed US studies published between 1992 and 2007. Gallup's estimate is higher: one-half to two times the salary. Count your own costs: hiring, training, the weeks until the new person is up to speed, and the overtime while the place is empty.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A TEAM OF 40

Leavers	6 voluntary, in one year
Rate	6 ÷ 40 = 15%
Cost	6 × 21% of €30,000 = €37,800

The median of the case studies, as a first estimate. The team and its numbers are invented.

OUR READING

The rate says how many people left. The exit interview says why, when it is too late. Only the conversation before it can still change the answer.

Sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2026; Heather Boushey & Sarah Jane Glynn, Center for American Progress, 2012; Shane McFeely & Ben Wigert, Gallup, 2019

The 21% excludes executives and physicians. The example is the editors'.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The stay conversation card

One card for a conversation with each person in the team every quarter, before anyone has decided anything. Fifteen minutes, one note, one action.

01 What keeps you here people, work, place: the ties that matter

02 What fits, and what does not the job, the schedule, the way to work

03 What would make you look elsewhere an honest answer is worth more than a polite one

04 What you want to be able to do in a year a skill, a task, a role

05 One thing I will do with a date

06 When we talk again in three months, or sooner if something changes

Source: Terence R. Mitchell et al., Academy of Management Journal, 2001 (via Abstract)

The editors' proposal for practice, built on the three parts of job embeddedness (Mitchell et al., 2001).

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

42% of Employee Turnover Is Preventable but Often Ignored
Corey Tatel & Ben Wigert, Gallup, 2024
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/646538/employee-turnover-preventable-often-ignored.aspx

This Fixable Problem Costs U.S. Businesses $1 Trillion
Shane McFeely & Ben Wigert, Gallup, 2019
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/247391/fixable-problem-costs-businesses-trillion.aspx

'Great Attrition' or 'Great Attraction'? The choice is yours
Aaron De Smet et al., McKinsey Quarterly, 2021 · via Excerpts, through web search
https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/people-and-organizational-performance/our-insights/great-attrition-or-great-attraction-the-choice-is-yours

The Great Attrition is making hiring harder. Are you searching the right talent pools?
McKinsey & Company, 2022 · via Excerpts, through web search
https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/people-and-organizational-performance/our-insights/the-great-attrition-is-making-hiring-harder-are-you-searching-the-right-talent-pools

Why people stay: Using job embeddedness to predict voluntary turnover
Terence R. Mitchell et al., Academy of Management Journal, 2001 · via Abstract
https://doi.org/10.5465/3069391

The unfolding model of voluntary turnover: A replication and extension
Thomas W. Lee et al., Academy of Management Journal, 1999 · via Secondary summaries of the model
https://doi.org/10.5465/257015

There Are Significant Business Costs to Replacing Employees
Heather Boushey & Sarah Jane Glynn, Center for American Progress, 2012
https://www.americanprogress.org/article/there-are-significant-business-costs-to-replacing-employees/

Job Openings and Labor Turnover – August 2026
U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2026
https://www.bls.gov/news.release/archives/jolts_09292026.htm

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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